

The Rise of Nationalism in Europe: From Utopian Vision to Nation-State

Tracing the journey of an idea that redrew the map of the nineteenth century.



KEY INSIGHT: We treat 'Nationalism' as the protagonist of this story—born in a dream, forged in revolution, hardened by conflict, and eventually corrupted by imperialism.

1848: The Utopian Prologue



The Torch of Enlightenment

Carried by a female figure, symbolizing the path to liberty.

The Debris

Shattered remains of absolutist institutions (monarchies) lie in the foreground.

The Heavens

Christ and angels gaze down, symbolizing fraternity among nations.

The Train of Nations

Distinct peoples identified by flags and costumes, not just subjects of a King.

French artist Frédéric Sorrieu visualised a world made up of "democratic and Social Republics." In this utopian vision, people are grouped as distinct nations.

KEY INSIGHT Nationalism began as a vision of liberty and fraternity, diametrically opposed to the absolutist institutions of the past.

1789: The Transfer of Sovereignty

Nationalism as a political reality began with the French Revolution.

It marked the first clear transfer of sovereignty from the monarchy to a body of French citizens.

The Measures of Identity:

- *La Patrie* (the fatherland) and *Le Citoyen* (the citizen) emphasised a united community enjoying equal rights under a constitution.
- A new French flag, the tricolour, replaced the royal standard.
- The Estates General was elected by active citizens and renamed the National Assembly.

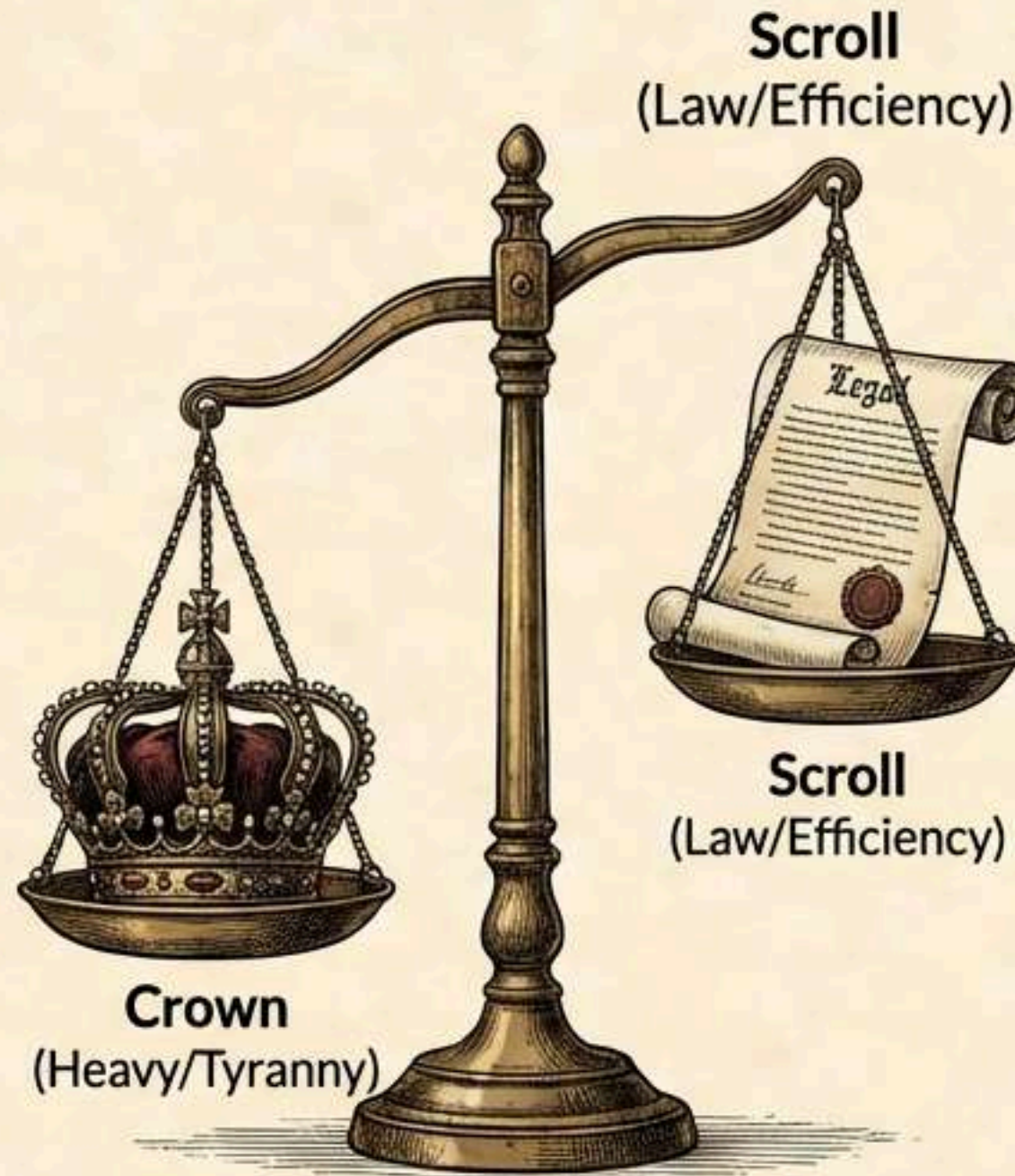


KEY INSIGHT: The Revolution proclaimed that it was the people who would henceforth constitute the nation and shape its destiny.

The Napoleonic Paradox: Rationalising the State



Napoleon destroyed democracy in France, yet in the administrative field, he incorporated revolutionary principles to make the whole system more rational and efficient.



The Civil Code of 1804 (Napoleonic Code):

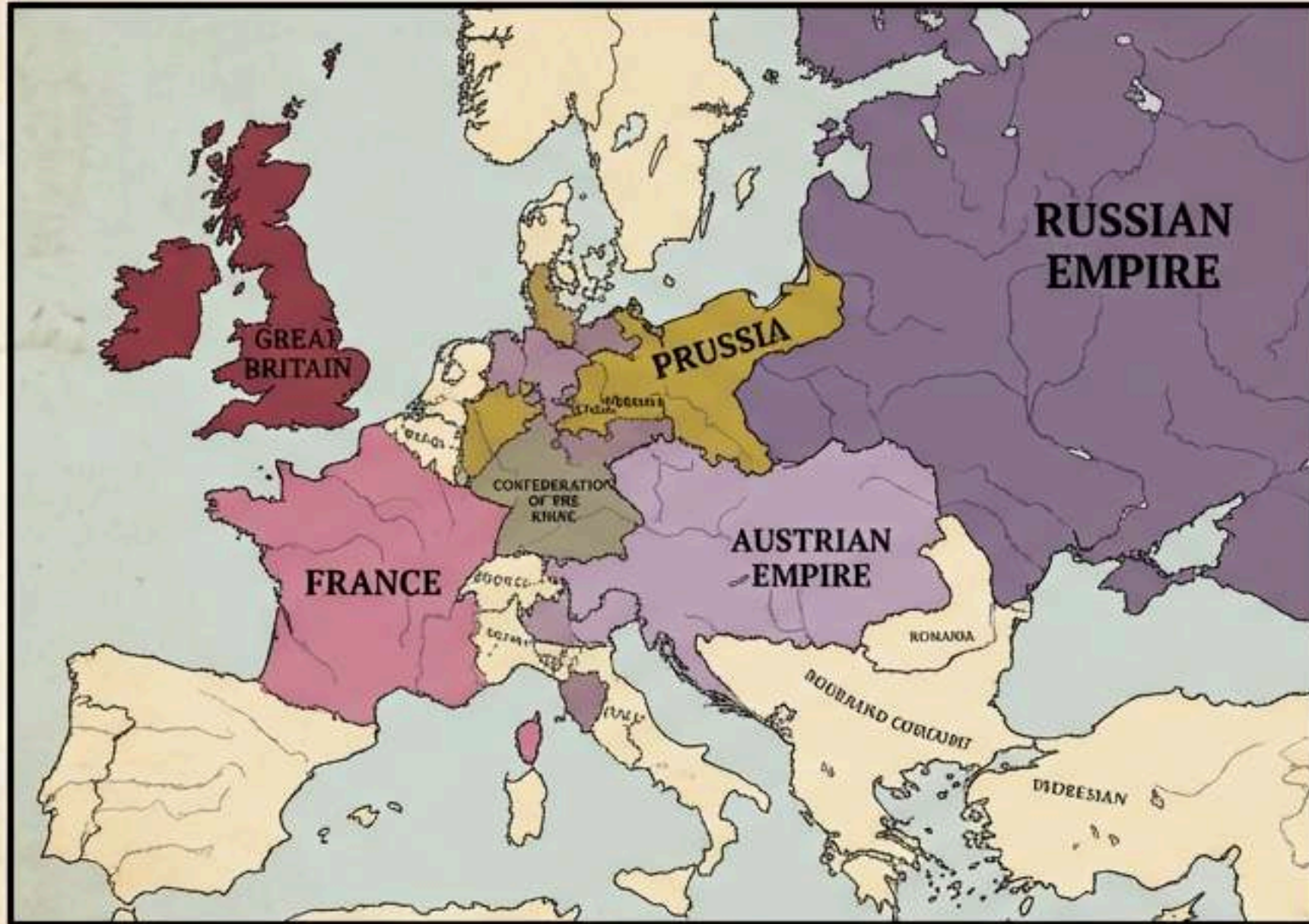
- Abolished all privileges based on birth.
- Established equality before the law.
- Secured the right to property.

The Export:

In the Dutch Republic, Switzerland, Italy, and Germany, Napoleon simplified administrative divisions, abolished the feudal system, and freed peasants from serfdom.

KEY INSIGHT: Nationalism was initially exported by French armies, mixing the gift of administrative efficiency with the burden of foreign rule.

1815: The Empire Strikes Back



Following the defeat of Napoleon, European governments were driven by a spirit of conservatism.

The Congress of Vienna:

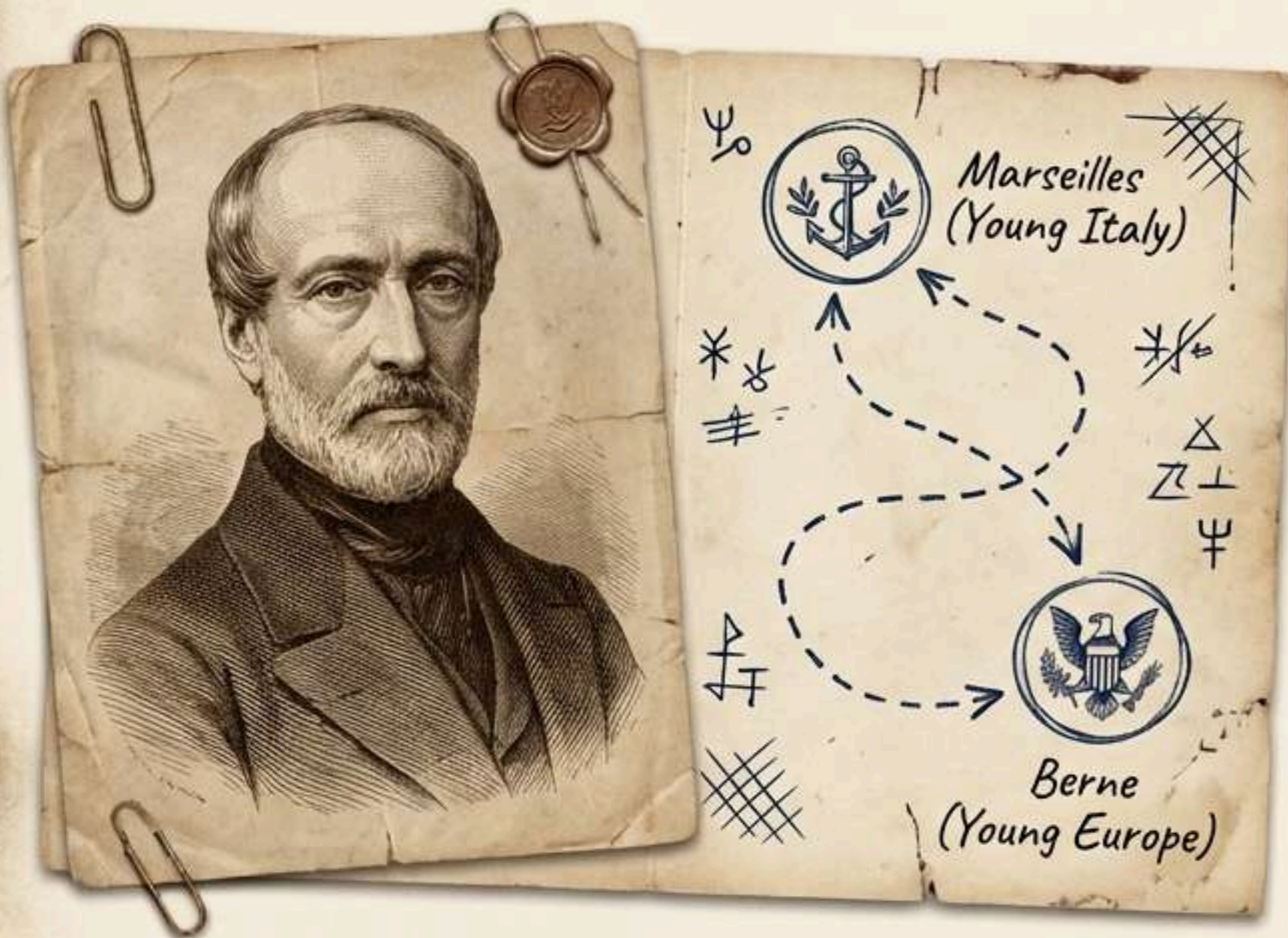
Representatives of Britain, Russia, Prussia, and Austria met to undo the changes of the Napoleonic wars.

The Restoration:

- The Bourbon dynasty was restored to power in France.
- France lost the territories it had annexed.
- Autocratic monarchies strengthened control; criticism and dissent were not tolerated.

KEY INSIGHT: The conservative order tried to restore the past, but the memory of the French Revolution continued to inspire the liberal-nationalists.

The Underground Resistance: Giuseppe Mazzini



With dissent banned, nationalism went underground. Secret societies sprang up to train revolutionaries.

The Protagonist: Giuseppe Mazzini (born in Genoa, 1807), member of the Carbonari.

The Philosophy: Mazzini believed God had intended nations to be the natural units of mankind. Italy could not continue to be a 'patchwork of small states and kingdoms.'

The Impact: Metternich described him as "the most dangerous enemy of our social order."

KEY INSIGHT: When the idea was banned from the palaces, it thrived in the shadows of secret societies.

The Soul of the Nation: Romanticism and Culture



Nationalism was not shaped by war alone. **Romanticism** was a cultural movement that criticised the glorification of science, focusing instead on emotions, intuition, and mystical feelings.

Das Volk: Johann Gottfried Herder claimed true German culture was to be discovered among the common people through folk songs and dances.

The Weapon of Language: In Poland, language became a weapon of resistance. After Russian occupation, the use of Polish in Church gatherings became a symbol of the struggle against Russian dominance.

KEY INSIGHT: A nation is defined not just by borders, but by a shared cultural consciousness (*Volkgeist*).

1848: The Failed Liberal Revolution



Context: The 1830s brought great economic hardship, hunger, and revolt across Europe.

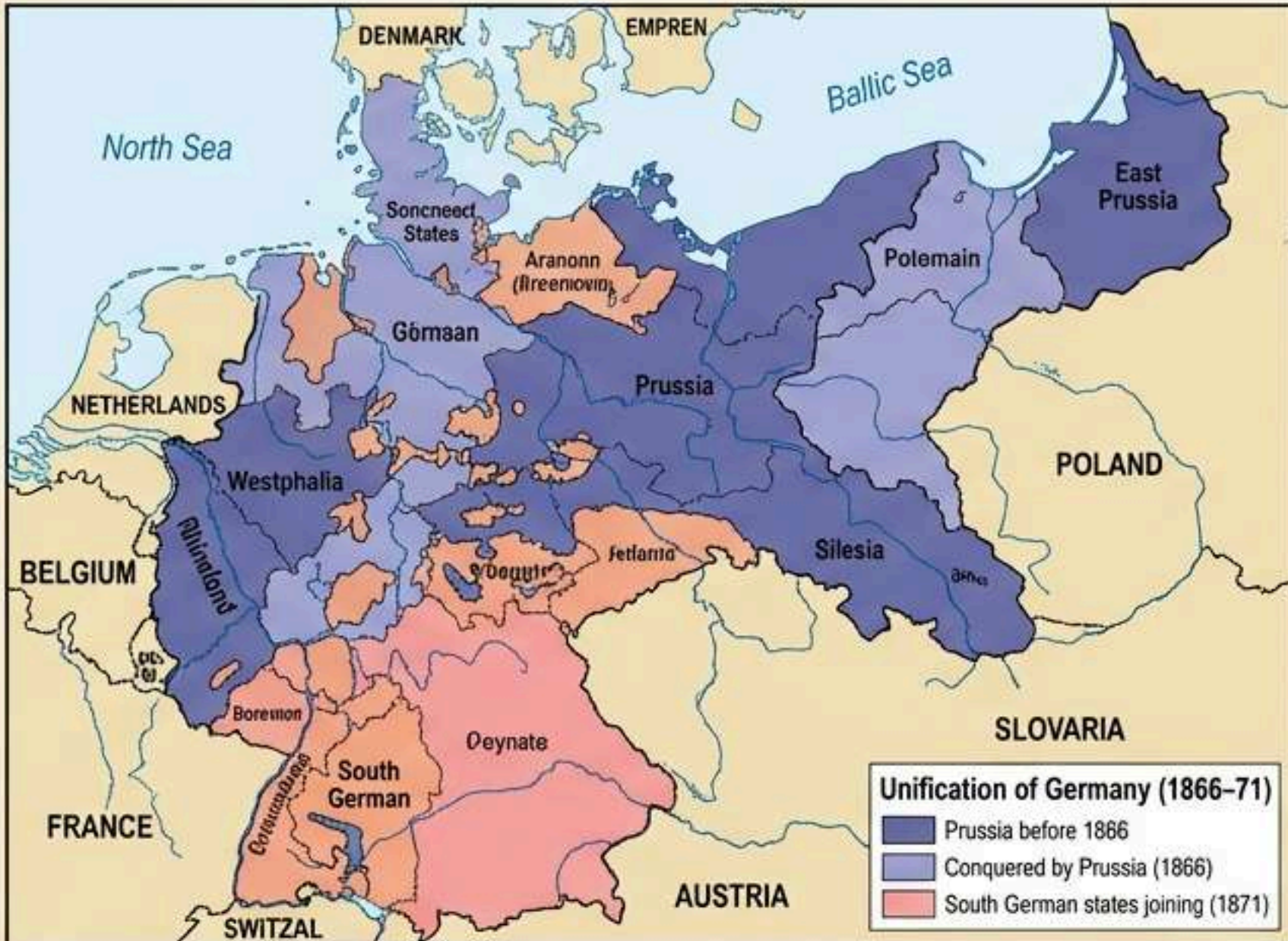
The Frankfurt Parliament: On 18 May 1848, 831 elected representatives marched to the Church of St Paul to draft a constitution for a German nation.

The Failure: They offered the crown to Friedrich Wilhelm IV, King of Prussia. He rejected it and joined other monarchs to oppose the assembly.

Outcome: The parliament lost the support of workers and artisans and was disbanded.

KEY INSIGHT: The attempt to create a nation through democratic consensus failed; the initiative would soon pass to the aristocracy and the army.

Germany: Can the Army be the Architect?



The Shift: After 1848, nationalism moved away from democracy. Prussia took over leadership.

The Architect: Otto von Bismarck carried out the process with the help of the Prussian army and bureaucracy.

The Process: Three wars over seven years (vs Austria, Denmark, France) ended in Prussian victory.

The Climax: January 1871, Prussian King William I was proclaimed German Emperor at Versailles.

KEY INSIGHT: The new German Empire demonstrated the dominance of Prussian state power—unification from above, not below.

Italy: A Patchwork Stitched by Diplomacy and War



The Fragmented Reality: Mid-19th century Italy was divided into seven states. Only Sardinia-Piedmont was ruled by an Italian house.

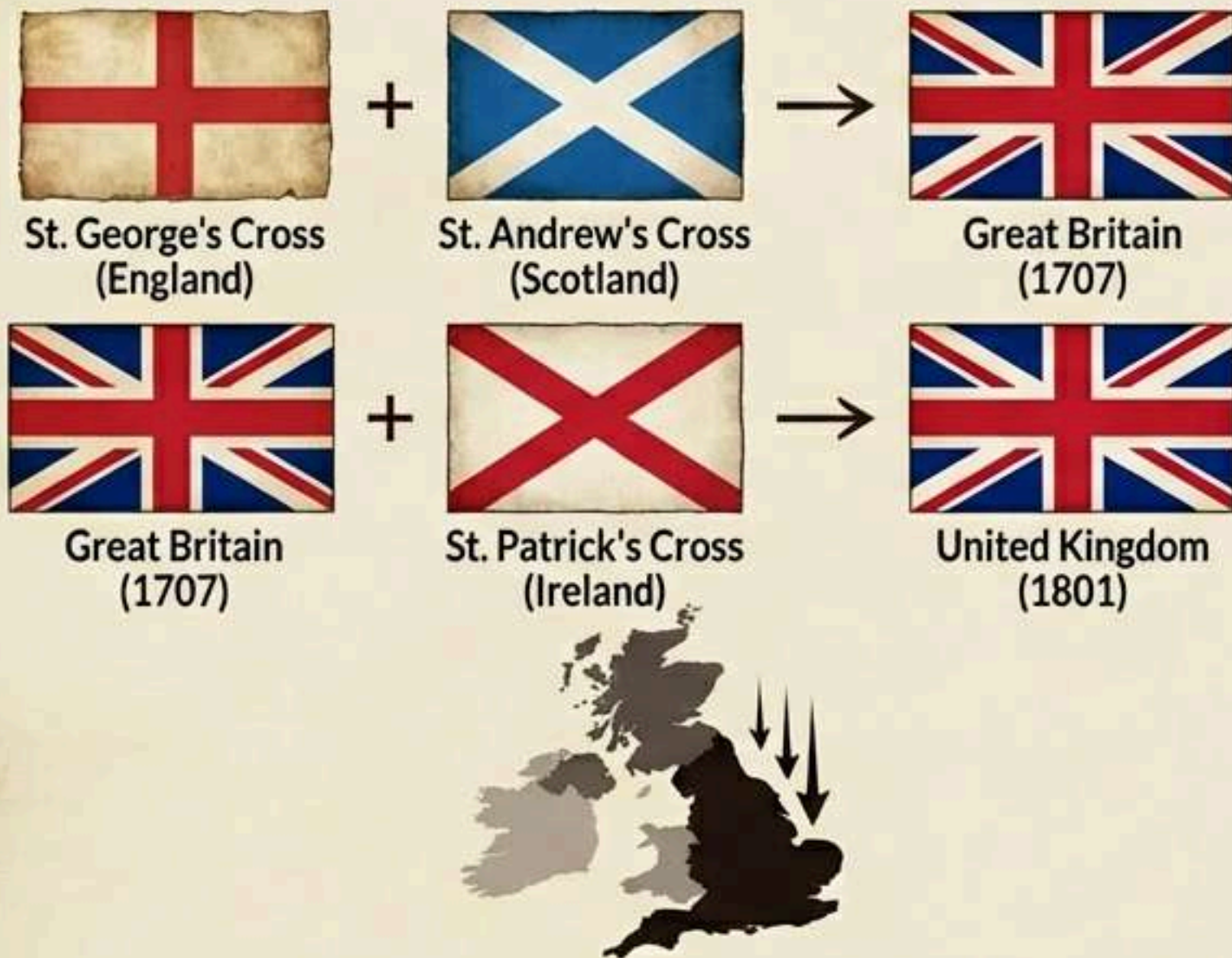
The Brain (Cavour): Chief Minister Cavour led the movement. Through a diplomatic alliance with France, Sardinia-Piedmont defeated Austrian forces (1859).

The Sword (Garibaldi): Giuseppe Garibaldi and his armed volunteers marched into South Italy (1860), winning peasant support to drive out the Spanish rulers.

Result: In 1861, Victor Emmanuel II was proclaimed king of united Italy.

KEY INSIGHT: Unification required both the legitimacy of a crown (Sardinia) and the fire of a revolutionary (Garibaldi).

Britain: The Strange Case of Evolution



There was no 'British nation' prior to the 18th century. The English nation grew in wealth and power, imposing influence on the islands.

- **1688:** English parliament seized power from the monarchy.
- **1707: Act of Union** formed 'Great Britain.' Scotland effectively came under English influence.
- **1801:** Ireland forcibly incorporated into the UK.
- **Cultural Suppression:** Promotion of the British flag, National Anthem, and English language over local identities.

KEY INSIGHT: Britain was not built on a shared dream, but forged by the steady political dominance of England over its neighbours.

Visualising the Nation: Marianne and Germania



FRANCE.
Attributes: Red Cap
(Liberty), Tricolour,
Cockade.



GERMANY.
Attributes: Crown of
Oak Leaves (Heroism),
Sword (Readiness to fight).

Artists found a way to give a face to a nation by personifying it, often as a female figure. These were allegories.

Marianne: Statues erected in public squares to remind the public of the national symbol of unity.

Germania: Visualised to represent the strength and heroism of the German people.

KEY INSIGHT: The nation needed a face to convert abstract loyalty into emotional devotion.

The Corruption of the Idea: Imperialism and the Balkans



The Shift: By the late 19th century, nationalism lost its liberal-democratic sentiment and became a narrow creed.

The Balkan Powder Keg: A region of ethnic variation under the disintegration of the Ottoman Empire.

The Conflict: As the Ottoman Empire collapsed, the Balkan peoples fought for independence based on nationality.

Imperialism: The big European powers manipulated these aspirations to further their own imperial aims.

KEY INSIGHT: Nationalism aligned with Imperialism to create a **volatile environment** that would lead to war.

1914: The Catastrophe and the Legacy



The Catastrophe: Rivalries over trade, colonies, and naval might, focused on the Balkans, led to the First World War.

The Irony: Nationalism, aligned with imperialism, led Europe to disaster.

The Global Legacy: Anti-imperial movements in colonies (like India) began to develop their own nationalism to fight for independent nation-states.

KEY INSIGHT: Despite the disaster, the idea of the 'nation-state' was now accepted as natural and universal. The utopian dream of 1848 had become the rigid reality of the 20th century.

Timeline & Terminology: The Revision Sheet

Timeline

1789: French Revolution (The Spark)

1804: Napoleonic Code (Civil Code)

1815: Congress of Vienna (Conservative Restoration)

1834: Zollverein (Customs Union)

1848: Revolutions; Frankfurt Parliament

1861: Victor Emmanuel II proclaimed King of United Italy

1871: German Empire proclaimed

Glossary

Absolutist: A government with no restraints on its power.

Utopian: A vision of society so ideal it is unlikely to exist.

Suffrage: The right to vote.

Ethnic: Relates to a common racial, tribal, or cultural origin.

Final Takeaway: Nationalism reshaped the mental and political world of Europe, moving sovereignty from the monarch to the citizen.